



**SESSION CHAIRPERSON SHANKKAR AIYAR
WITH SHEIKH AHMED BIN SAEED AL MAKTOUM**

indeed be full of challenges. But the second part of the theme does not apply to us, as the UAE has been looking forward to these challenges and has been facing them to ensure the continuity of the development that we have achieved so far. We always endeavour with the help of our wise leadership to develop ourselves and the environment we work in. We have created our own example and built a multifarious economy without depending on natural resources. We started from the vision of change and are a part of a well-knit society connected to the global community. The people of the UAE have always proved that they are capable of turning challenges and risks into opportunities. Our direction is forward with steady steps.

The recent financial crisis convinced us more about the ability of our people. It has proved the importance of the UAE on the world stage and also made us proud of what we have achieved during the last few years. We are now working on improving our strategies and plans according to international requirements. We are sure that the centre of power has started shifting from the shores of the Atlantic Ocean to the Indian Ocean. The UAE will continue to achieve the develop-

ment enhanced by the strong local demand and by the economic integration of the young population in the region, with about 200 million people under the age of 25.

The UAE will not only be a country exporting crude oil but it is seeking to play a vital role in the economy of knowledge, which decides the possibilities of development of countries and their economic boom. Education plays a very important role here; this explains why we are putting so much emphasis on education, especially higher education. Our concentration is on improving the quality of it so as to empower our sons and daughters with the important skills of creativity. The creativity that distinguishes the people of the UAE in addition to the wisdom that was reflected by the vision of His Highness Sheikh Khalifa bin Zaid Al Nahayan, President of the country, and his brother His Highness Sheikh Mohammed bin Rashid Al Maktoum, vice-president of the state, the prime minister and the ruler of Dubai, through the modernisation of our policies and programmes.

We have provided more opportunities for experts, specialists and investors from across the world to come to us and share their experience with us. Be sure that their investments will be protected. When we got our independence in December 1971, there were only 45 graduates in the UAE, but now there are thousands of graduates passing out every year. The number of women joining universities is the highest in the world—92 per cent.

No doubt that the strong presence of India has made the world stronger and enriched its economy, markets and stability. We see that India, which is witnessing speedy development and trying to occupy a leading position in world economy, will be able to guide these changes with the support of the UAE, which stands by it and will continue to do so in its forthcoming giant projects. There's still a lot we have to do together.

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DISCUSSION

Q. How is Dubai coping with the debt crisis? The international markets are concerned about how Dubai is going to deal with its huge problems.

A. What happened in Dubai, in a way was like the Hiroshima-Nagasaki bombs that rocked the whole world. I think the Middle East is one of the nodal points of business and is considered a benchmark. But it seems like people were confused between Dubai World as a company and also Dubai as a state within the UAE and that led to con-

fusion. Dubai World is a company with more than 100 components; it has more than 1,000 different businesses within it. We are now trying to separate bad business from good.

Q. How do you restore the confidence in Dubai as an investment destination?

A. Even now a lot of people are coming to Dubai to invest. What was wrong with Dubai World was its real estate business. You can see that this business around the world is going down. But our government gave its support to Dubai World and

appointed a financial expert for restructuring. We did not touch any other business in the company and now they are functioning very well. We are confident that we will be able to come up with the best solution, which will be in the interest of everyone who deals with Dubai World, and move further.

Q. What are the issues where the two countries are expanding cooperation. Why can't you hand over Dawood Ibrahim as a gesture of goodwill to India?

A. Security issues figured

prominently when His Highness, the ruler of Dubai, met the Indian Prime Minister Manmohan Singh. We have said that more coordination between the two sides would make the relationship much closer through direct contacts. And in case of Dawood Ibrahim, I don't think he is in Dubai, that's for sure. Our trade is growing and is at \$44 billion. We are always looking to grow further. The relationship between the two countries is not only at a political level but it is between the people of both countries and their cultures.